

YASBANT NEGI



— DECEMBER 7, 2008

Chand and Fiza come out to declare their marriage at a TV station in Delhi

JANUARY 28, 2009

- Chand goes missing. Fiza creates a ruckus, alleging that he has been kidnapped at the behest of his family.

JANUARY 29, 2009

- A day later, she attempts suicide at her Mohali residence. Chand resurfaces in Gurgaon.

— FEBRUARY 2, 2009

- Fiza airs her woes at a press conference in Chandigarh, says Chand has deceived her.

CHAND MOHAMMAD AND FIZA IN HAPPIER TIMES

Texts, Lies & VIDEOTAPE

The Chand-Fiza saga combines politics, power, illicit romance and rejection to create a real-life soap opera

| By Ramesh Vinayak |

It's a modern-day mix of a soap opera and the theatre of the absurd. Sensational and titillating, it has captivated audiences nationwide mainly because it has all the necessary ingredients—politics, power, extramarital romance, religious conversion, a fairy-tale wedding, deceit, lust, longing and angst for revenge. Move over Ekta Kapoor, reality is spicier than fiction.

The real life saga, however, is also about remakes, and not happy ones for sure, as the relationship between

the twice-married couple of former Haryana deputy chief minister Chander Mohan alias Chand Mohammad and his ladylove and ex-law officer of the state Government, Anuradha Bali alias Fiza, hurtled towards a bitter denouement last week. The sordid saga, a god-sent TRP ratings-pusher for hyperventilating news channels, only revealed the new depth to which political and social values have plummeted.

By all accounts, it was a bizarre marriage of convenience that not only breached social norms but also amounted to a brazen act of bigamy,

an offence under the Hindu Marriage Act. Yet, after Chander Mohan, 46-year-old father of two teenagers, and divorcee Anuradha Bali, 33, embraced Islam and announced their second marriage, they spent much of their honeymoon relentlessly courting the media to project their alliance as a made-in-heaven affair. So much so they virtually thumbed their noses at a ruling by the Supreme Court forbidding conversion to Islam as a ruse for a second marriage by non-Muslims. Instead, Chand took the high moral ground, saying he was an exception among politicians who kept their extramarital affairs under wraps, and Fiza threatened 'a stone-for-brick' response if his first wife Seema Bishnoi dared to challenge their 'marriage' in court.

Such bravado didn't cut much ice with an embarrassed Congress Government which lost no time in stripping Chand of his official position, reducing him to a mere MLA. The state Government sacked Fiza as additional advocate general, a position she had wangled by means of her